

# The River Fleet

No. 127

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

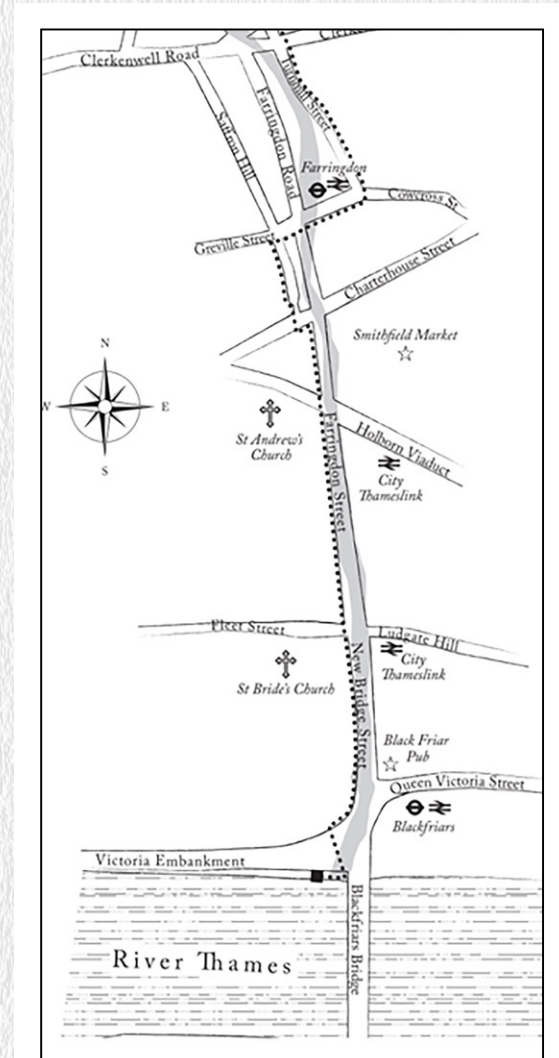
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The River Fleet is only five miles long, running from Hampstead to the Thames near Blackfriars. The area around Farringdon had the Fleet Telephone Exchange. Old oyster tubs have been found. The riverbanks had prisons like Ludgate, Newgate, and Fleet Prison. Fleet Prison was famous for holding notable prisoners and for "Fleet Marriages" until 1753.

Ludgate Circus was an old crossing. It and others were replaced by bridges built by Wren. Much of the river was later covered. New Bridge Street covers part of it.

Nearby are the Holy Well of St Bride, Bridewell Palace, and the old prison gatehouse. Whitefriars and Blackfriars Monasteries once dominated the area, later becoming semi-independent zones called Alsatia.

At the river's mouth, the Black Friar pub marks Blackfriars Monastery, later used for theatre by Shakespeare's company among others. The Fleet now flows underground in Bazalgette's sewers, beneath Victoria Embankment. Storm drains and hidden tunnels still carry the river water today.



*The River Fleet*